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A few of the many advantages of RFID over bar coding include read-write capabilities, parallel reading, reusability and robustness. A classic example is the use of tags for production management in the Mahindra & Mahindra paint shop on the Scorpio product line. Apart from the heat in the oven, a bar code would never survive the paint that would fall on it!

At ITC Bangalore, which has a range of brands, RFID technology effectively routes the right grade and blend of tobacco to the right packaging line.

While the benefits of industrial use of RFID tags are undisputed, cost becomes a consideration at the retail level. Also, different countries use different frequency bands, and so tracking across borders becomes an issue. Gen 2 standards have attempted that at least the EPC (European Product Code)—a unique identifier for a product in the supply chain—would be read across the different frequencies.

While implementing a system could cost anywhere between Rs 50 lakh to a crore, the strategy should be to identify the business process for the “perfect fit.”



WHEN AND WHERE DOES

RFID technology has seen limited use in India thus far, but implementations are being experimented with by a range of businesses. In some cases, bar codes are not even an option. Here's what some who've implemented it have to say about the feasibility of RFID deployment



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Two years ago, we implemented an RFID system for tracking body shells in the Pre-Treatment and Electro-Deposition (PTED) process of the paint-shop at our Nasik plant.

As part of the PTED process, the shells undergo high temperatures and chemical reactions. Typical solutions such as bar codes would not be able to withstand these extreme conditions. We therefore went in for passive, rewritable RFID tags.

At the end of the body shop process, a body shell is loaded on a hanger, and details such as the body serial number, model and colour code are mapped to the unique hanger code in the system. The hanger then transports the body shell to the PTED shop, where it gets dropped on to a skid to which a rewrite-type RFID tag is attached. The details of the body shell are written onto the tag when the skid passes the RFID antenna, and simultaneously, the status is updated in the system. The skid with the body shell then passes through the PTED process. At the exit, the body shell is picked up by a hanger, at which point the details on the tag are read and mapped with the hanger code, and the status is again updated in the system.

In the near future, we plan to extend RFID tracking to our entire line, from body shop to vehicle assembly and roll-out.